STIVEN CATALYST

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# MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.




STRATEGY

## THE RHYTHM OF MANAGEMENT: THE DAY, THE WEEK, THE MONTH

How fragmented a manager's day is, where the time of chief executives goes, the daily, weekly and monthly routines that give it a shape, and a card for your own rhythm.

**< 9 min**

was how long half of the activities of the chief executives Mintzberg observed lasted; one in ten went past an hour.

MINTZBERG, 1975

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# In this issue

A manager's week fills itself: calls, questions, problems that cannot wait. This issue is about the few fixed routines that keep the important things from being crowded out: a short daily check, a weekly conversation, a monthly look back.

Henry Mintzberg found that most of what chief executives did lasted minutes, not hours. Decades later, 27 CEOs spent 72% of their working time in meetings. Lean answers with standard work for leaders and short daily meetings in tiers; Andy Grove with a one-to-one of at least an hour. In a children's hospital, daily huddles were part of an effort that almost halved one kind of serious event, though never on their own.

*Stiven Janaqi* EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST


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## HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

**Figure**
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

**Our reading**
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

**Practice**
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

# Nine minutes

Henry Mintzberg followed five chief executives for a week each and recorded everything they did. In 1975 he summed up what he had seen in Harvard Business Review.

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“Half the activities engaged in by the five chief executives of my study lasted less than nine minutes, and only 10% exceeded one hour.”

| 5 | ½ | 10% |
|---|---|---|
| chief executives, one week each | of their activities lasted less than nine minutes | lasted more than an hour |

Mintzberg set the folklore of the calm, systematic planner against what he saw: work that was brief, varied and constantly interrupted, and that leaned towards action rather than reflection.

**OUR READING**

If the day is cut into nine-minute pieces, the important things need fixed places. Otherwise the urgent ones take them all.

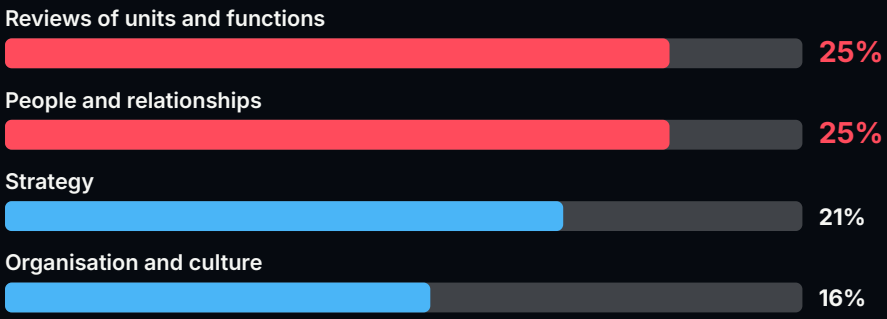
Source: Henry Mintzberg, Harvard Business Review, 1975

THE NUMBERS

# Where 60,000 hours went

Michael Porter and Nitin Nohria had the assistants of 27 CEOs log their time, around the clock, in 15-minute blocks, for 13 weeks: nearly 60,000 hours. The CEOs worked 62.5 hours a week on average.

SHARE OF THE CEOS' WORKING TIME




**72%** of working time in meetings

**43%** on work that advanced their own agenda

**36%** reacting to issues as they came up

OUR READING

Even at the top, more than a third of the time goes to reacting. A fixed rhythm is what keeps the rest from going the same way.

Source: Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018

The four areas are shares of all working time and do not add up to 100%.

THE MODEL

# A rhythm in three beats

In Creating a Lean Culture, David Mann names four elements of lean management: standard work for leaders, visual controls, a daily accountability process and discipline. Andy Grove adds the weekly conversation.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 01 | **The day: short meetings in tiers** | The team at the start of the shift, then the supervisors, then the managers: a problem travels up the same morning. |
| 02 | **The week: one-to-ones** | At least an hour, with an agenda the employee prepares; more often with someone new to the task, less often with a veteran. |
| 03 | **The month: a look back** | The numbers of the month, what the daily meetings kept bringing up, and one change for the next month. |

Mann estimated that standard work fills about 80% of a team leader's day. Higher up it fills less, and consists mostly of following up the level below.

OUR READING

A rhythm is not more meetings. It is fewer, at fixed times, each with one job.

Sources: David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005 (via Routledge contents, 3rd ed., 2015; Lean Blog interview, 2014); Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast, 2006; Andrew S. Grove, 1983 (via Google re:Work's quotation and summaries of the book)

The day follows Mann, the week Grove; the monthly look back is the editors'.

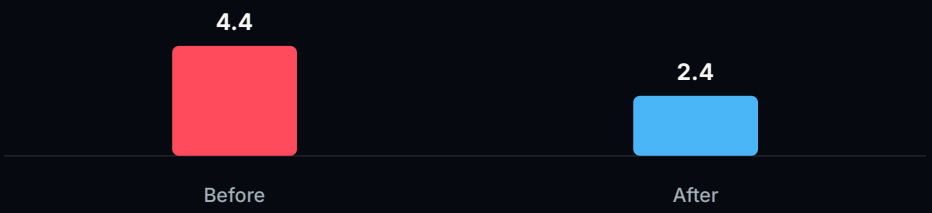
More in the essay — Ten minutes before the shift: what the team needs to know before the work starts

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

# What a daily huddle can do

A children's hospital with 539 beds introduced short daily meetings in three tiers: on the wards, among charge nurses and among leaders. They looked ahead at risks, reported safety events and moved resources where they were needed.

UNRECOGNISED DETERIORATION ENDING IN INTENSIVE CARE, PER 10,000 PATIENT DAYS




The fall came with a bundle of measures: spotting risk early, frequent huddles on the wards, and ways of learning from each event. There was no control group, so the share of the huddles cannot be separated. A second study of the same hospital, based on 10 interviews and 6 focus groups, described how the huddles worked but measured no outcome.

OUR READING

A daily huddle is cheap. Its value is in what happens after it: the problem that someone takes away and closes.

Sources: Patrick W. Brady et al., Pediatrics, 2013; Linda M. Goldenhar et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2013

HOW IT IS MEASURED

# Check the rhythm, not the calendar

In Mann's system, standard work is written down and the level above checks whether it happened. The same works for your own routines.

1. **Write the routines down**
   Each beat with a time, a place and an owner.
2. **Mark each one, every day**
   Held or not, in one line.
3. **Count once a month**
   The share held, and why the others fell away.
4. **Change one thing**
   Move, shorten or drop the routine that keeps failing.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT LEAD'S MONTH

| | |
|---|---|
| **Daily** | 19 of 22 meetings held |
| **Weekly** | 5 of 8 one-to-ones held |
| **Monthly** | 1 of 1 review held |

The weekly beat is the one that breaks, so that is where the change goes. The numbers are invented.

Source: Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast, 2006

The steps and the example are the editors'.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

# The rhythm card

One card for the routines of your role. Fill it in once, keep it where you work, and check it at the end of each week.

**01 Every day** time, place, ten minutes, who attends

**02 What the daily meeting looks at** safety, yesterday's numbers, today's risks

**03 Every week** one-to-ones: with whom, how long, who brings the agenda

**04 Every month** the review: which numbers, which question

**05 What I stop doing** to make room for the routines

**06 Who checks me** the person who sees whether the routines happened

Sources: David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005 (via Routledge contents, 3rd ed., 2015; Lean Blog interview, 2014); Andrew S. Grove, 1983 (via Google re:Work's quotation and summaries of the book)

A practice proposed by the editors, after Mann's daily accountability and Grove's one-to-ones.

Open the tool: Shift Pulse stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-pulse/

SOURCES AND METHOD

# Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

**The Manager's Job: Folklore and Fact**
Henry Mintzberg, Harvard Business Review, 1975
https://hbr.org/1990/03/the-managers-job-folklore-and-fact

**How CEOs Manage Time**
Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018
https://hbr.org/2018/07/how-ceos-manage-time

**Creating a Lean Culture: Tools to Sustain Lean Conversions**
David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005 · via Routledge contents, 3rd ed., 2015; Lean Blog interview, 2014

**Creating a Lean Culture That Lasts: A Conversation with David Mann**
Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast, 2006
https://www.leanblog.org/2006/11/creating-a-lean-culture-david-mann/

**High Output Management**
Andrew S. Grove, 1983 · via Google re:Work's quotation and summaries of the book

**Huddling for high reliability and situation awareness**
Linda M. Goldenhar et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2013
https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/23744537/

**Improving situation awareness to reduce unrecognized clinical deterioration and serious safety events**
Patrick W. Brady et al., Pediatrics, 2013
https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/23230078/

**EDITORIAL METHOD**

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



# MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

## ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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